

open, protecting their men and other male members from security forces. Whenever troops have marched into a village or have been poised to storm a Maoist stronghold, these women and children let out a shrill warning, a whistle-like wail which rings across villages and spreads the word of the impending danger. This unique

empty of men. When policemen enter their homes with a mission to molest them or take away their men, they take up the scythe. Some women have developed political consciousness and joined the ranks and even taken military training. Many Maoist squads are headed by women, as was proved by the abduction of the office-

offered money by Maoists to act as sentinels and messengers. This is nothing but coercion. I would like to hear some real names of women Maoist leaders. But it is important for more and more Leftist women organisations to penetrate these areas and dispel the myths."

However loud the Left may shout from the rooftops that women do not support the Maoists—quite conveniently forgetting names like Jagori Baske or Rina Sarkar who are Peoples Liberation Guerrilla Army

“The Left movement is dying and the Front misrule is hastening the end. It is heartening to see the return of the real Left.”

CHHOTON DAS, general secretary, Committee for the Release of Political Prisoners

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**ARMED WOMEN
MAOISTS AT
A SHOW OF
STRENGTH
IN LALGARH**

warning system was earlier adopted in Singur where women blew conch shells at the sight of policemen.

The vandalism of their homes by the troops and policemen and random arrests have brought out the mother instinct in these women. They have realised that their children must have schools to study in and men must have land to till. For months now, children have gone without schools where troops have set up camps while the villages are almost

in-charge of the Sankhrail police station, Atindranath Datta. The operation was led by two young women.

Shyamali Gupta, working president of the All India Democratic Women's Association, which owes affiliation to the CPI(M), dismisses all talk of women sympathising with the Maoists. "Maoists have taken away the men and the impoverished women are lured by money. Some of those arrested recently went on record saying that they had been

legends in the forest land—it is apparent that there is a massive support base among women for the rebels. The top Maoist leader in Bengal, Koteswar Rao or Kishenji, in a masterstroke of a strategy, did not make any heavy-duty demands which would have been impossible for the state Government to fulfil. Instead, he called for the release of 14 women prisoners who were arrested during the beginning of Operation Lalgarh in exchange for Datta. With